



SAN FRANCISCO, CALIFORNIA USA

Farm-to-Fork California Cuisine

San Francisco and the surrounding Bay Area are geographically blessed. The sparkling waters of the Pacific frame gorgeous vistas at every turn, from pastel-hued Victorian houses and vertiginous city streets to the famous Golden Gate Bridge. The region's cuisine rivals the setting, with innovative farm-fresh dishes to sample throughout the Bay Area.



A bird's-eye view of California reveals a wave-battered coastline, towering sequoia forests, lush vineyards, peach orchards, and orange groves. California may have given the world Hollywood, but the grand outdoors is its true celebrity. The influence of nature also pervades California's eponymous cuisine, which is rooted in the simple concept that ingredients should be healthy and homegrown.

It's easy to be part of the San Francisco feel-good spirit: join the locals on the bike trails that crisscross the city or test your balance rollerblading along the shaded paths in Golden Gate Park. Try a walk on the breezy waterfront, from lively Fisherman's Wharf (keep an eye out for its loudest residents – braying sea lions) to the sun-speckled Presidio parkland. North of the city lies Marin County – the birthplace of the mountain bike – where rugged Mount Tamalpais continues to offer the region's most exciting two-wheel adventures. The East Bay – and the progressive city of Berkeley – is also laced with green spaces, including Tilden Park. Take a dip in Lake Anza; stroll the aromatic Botanic Gardens; and hop on an antique carousel.

The “farm-to-fork” culinary movement – in which fresh, locally sourced ingredients rule – began in San Francisco and the Bay Area. One heady whiff in an outdoor market – and a juicy bite into a tender white peach – and you'll understand why. At San Francisco's popular Ferry Plaza Farmers Market on the Embarcadero, you can sniff and sample local produce while enjoying views of the Bay Bridge. Equally impressive is the Berkeley Bowl, which has the largest produce selection in northern California. Here, you'll see locals picking out organic pomegranates, hefting eggplants, and holding persimmons up to the light to choose the best of the best.

Many Bay Area chefs cultivate close relationships with regional growers, so what arrives at your table may have been pulled from the soil only hours before. Fusing fresh seasonal ingredients with cooking skills honed in the finest French kitchens gives delicious perfection – dishes like roasted scallops with Belgian endives and lemon gremolata, and parsnip and apple soup, populate the menus of California's gastronomic heroes, such as Alice Waters at her exceptional Chez Panisse (*see facing page*).



Above Unbeatable vistas of the San Francisco skyline and its surrounding hills can be had from the Golden Gate Bridge, the emblem of the city

California Wines

Viticulture began in California in the 18th century, when Spanish missionaries planted vines for their sacramental wines. Today, the Golden State produces more wine than the whole of Australia. California's most famous wine region is perhaps the **Napa Valley**, just north of the Bay Area, where the Mediterranean climate, favorable geology, and skilled modern winemaking techniques come together in some of the finest wines in the world. A visit to the Napa Valley, combining travel and frequent stops for tasting, is a must. You can explore independently by car, enjoying farm-fresh California cuisine along the way and spending the night at lovely B&Bs, or opt for the relaxed luxury of the **Napa Valley Wine Train** – a restaurant housed in vintage train cars (www.winetrain.com).

Three Days in the Bay Area

The Bay Area is anchored by the gorgeous city of San Francisco, with its world-class museums and impressive restaurants. To the east is the bohemian university town of Berkeley, and to the north, nature-filled Marin County.

DAY ONE Explore urban nature at **Golden Gate Park**, followed by a bike ride across Golden Gate Bridge into **Marin County**. Stop by the lovely harbor town of **Sausalito**, filled with art galleries and cafés. Ease into the evening in San Francisco's Italian **North Beach** neighborhood. Savor a grappa (or three) at **Tosca Café**, where you can enjoy the nostalgic atmosphere while listening to opera on the jukebox.

DAY TWO Visit the **Museum of Modern Art (SFMOMA)**, where the eye-catching building is as impressive as the art. Then shop till you drop at **Union Square**, which is ringed with boutiques and cafés where you can refuel over an ink-black espresso.

DAY THREE Head across the Oakland Bay Bridge to **Berkeley**, home to the famous University of California, and stroll colorful **Telegraph Avenue**, packed with street vendors and bookstores. For a dose of cultural history, stop in to the **Hearst Museum of Anthropology** on the University of California campus.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

San Francisco International Airport is 13 miles (21 km) from downtown. Get around on foot or by **BART** (Bay Area Rapid Transport) or **Muni** (San Francisco Municipal Railway).

WHERE TO STAY

The Greenwich Inn (inexpensive) is located in the Marina District. www.greenwichinn.com
Hotel Bijou (moderate) celebrates cinema history, with cozy rooms, red velvet curtains, and a small theater. www.hotelbijou.com
Claremont Resort (expensive) in the Berkeley Hills has leafy grounds, a splendid spa, and wonderful views. www.ksiresorts.com

TOURIST INFORMATION

San Francisco Convention and Visitors Bureau; www.onlyinsanfrancisco.com